

Current-Traditional Rhetoric: A Theory of Writing

Introduction

Current-Traditional Rhetoric (CTR) is arguably the most enduring and pervasive theory of writing instruction in the history of American higher education. Originating in the late nineteenth century, CTR dominated composition classrooms for roughly a hundred years before being challenged by process-oriented and social-epistemic alternatives in the 1960s and beyond. Despite sustained academic criticism, CTR remains deeply embedded in standardized testing regimes, secondary school curricula, and popular conceptions of what it means to write well. This report examines the historical origins of CTR, its core principles and pedagogical methods, the key figures and texts that shaped and critiqued it, the major criticisms leveled against it, and its persistent legacy in contemporary writing instruction.

1 Historical Origins

1.1 Alexander Bain and the Codification of Paragraph Theory

The intellectual foundations of Current-Traditional Rhetoric can be traced to the Scottish logician and rhetorician Alexander Bain, whose *English Composition and Rhetoric* (1866) established many of the prescriptive conventions that would govern American composition instruction for the next century. Bain's contribution was not so much the invention of new rhetorical theory as the systematic codification of existing principles into teachable rules. His treatment of the paragraph as the fundamental unit of composition proved especially influential. Bain articulated three governing principles for paragraph construction: unity (each paragraph should develop a single topic), coherence (sentences within a paragraph should be logically connected through conjunctions and transitional devices), and development, which subsequent current-traditionalists renamed *mass* or *proportion*, meaning that the paragraph topic must be expanded upon sufficiently to satisfy the reader.

Bain also advanced the classification of discourse into distinct modes—narration, description, exposition, and argumentation—a taxonomy that would become one of CTR’s most recognizable features. Although Samuel P. Newman had proposed a similar classification in *A Practical System of Rhetoric* as early as 1827, Bain’s formulation became the standard reference point for American textbook writers. These paragraph rules and modal categories went virtually unquestioned for a century, until composition theorists in the 1960s began investigating actual written paragraphs and discovered that professional essayists routinely and effectively violated Bain’s prescriptions.

1.2 Adams Sherman Hill and Harvard’s Influence

If Bain provided the theoretical scaffolding, Adams Sherman Hill provided the institutional machinery through which CTR became the dominant paradigm in American universities. Hill served as the Boylston Professor of Rhetoric at Harvard University from 1876 to 1904, a period during which Harvard’s English program was the most influential in the United States. His textbook *The Principles of Rhetoric* (1878), which remained in print until 1923, codified a view of rhetoric concerned almost exclusively with grammar and style, deliberately omitting the classical rhetorical canon of invention—the art of generating ideas and arguments. This omission was consequential. By stripping rhetoric of its inventive dimension, Hill effectively reduced writing instruction to matters of surface correctness and arrangement.

Harvard’s institutional prestige ensured that Hill’s curricular model was replicated across American universities as they expanded rapidly in the late nineteenth century. The establishment of required first-year composition courses, modeled on Harvard’s English A, became a near-universal feature of American higher education. These courses, shaped by Hill’s textbook and pedagogical philosophy, enshrined the current-traditional paradigm as the default mode of writing instruction. The emphasis on correctness, mechanical proficiency, and formal propriety reflected broader cultural anxieties about standardization and social mobility in the era of mass immigration and industrial expansion.

1.3 The Late Nineteenth-Century University Context

The rise of CTR cannot be understood apart from the transformation of the American university in the decades following the Civil War. The Morrill Land-Grant Acts (1862, 1890), the professionalization of academic disciplines, and the rapid growth of student enrollments created enormous demand for efficient, standardizable methods of writing instruction. Composition courses served a gatekeeping function, sorting students by their command of standard written English. CTR, with its emphasis on correctness and its reliance on easily assessable textual features, was ideally suited to this institutional role. The current-traditional paradigm emerged not merely from intellectual

conviction but from the convergence of historical forces, social needs, and cultural pressures that shaped the modern American university.

2 Core Principles

2.1 Product-Oriented Writing

The defining characteristic of CTR is its orientation toward the written product rather than the writing process. Under this paradigm, the quality of a piece of writing is judged by its conformity to established conventions of form, grammar, and style. The assumption is that good writing is writing that looks correct—that exhibits proper spelling, punctuation, syntax, and organizational structure. The messy, recursive, and often non-linear processes by which writers actually generate and revise text are largely invisible in the current-traditional framework. Writing is treated as the transcription of pre-existing thought: the writer first thinks, then writes, and the written product is evaluated as a more or less faithful rendering of that prior thought.

2.2 The Modes of Discourse

Central to CTR is the classification of writing into four modes of discourse: narration, description, exposition, and argumentation. Each mode is treated as a distinct form with its own conventions and purposes. Narration tells a story; description renders sensory experience; exposition explains or informs; argumentation persuades. In current-traditional pedagogy, students are typically asked to write essays that conform to a single mode, and mastery of each mode is treated as a discrete skill. This taxonomic approach has been criticized for its artificiality—real writing rarely conforms to a single mode—but it provided a convenient structure for organizing courses and textbooks.

2.3 The Five-Paragraph Essay

Perhaps no artifact of CTR is more recognizable than the five-paragraph essay, a formulaic structure consisting of an introductory paragraph with a thesis statement, three body paragraphs each developing a single supporting point, and a concluding paragraph that restates the thesis. While not explicitly prescribed by Bain or Hill, the five-paragraph essay is a logical extension of CTR's commitment to rigid formal structures and its reduction of rhetorical complexity to teachable templates. It became especially prevalent in secondary education, where it served as a manageable framework for both instruction and assessment.

2.4 Emphasis on Correctness

CTR places extraordinary weight on mechanical correctness—grammar, spelling, punctuation, and usage. Errors in these domains are treated not merely as lapses in convention but as failures of thought and discipline. The current-traditional classroom is one in which the red pen is the primary instrument of instruction, and the elimination of error is the primary pedagogical goal. This emphasis reflects the paradigm’s roots in a period when command of standard written English was explicitly linked to social respectability, class status, and professional advancement.

3 Pedagogical Methods

3.1 Model Essays and Imitation

In the current-traditional classroom, instruction typically proceeds through the analysis of model essays. Students read exemplary texts—often drawn from canonical literary or journalistic sources—and are expected to internalize their formal qualities through close study and imitation. The pedagogical logic is essentially Aristotelian in a narrow sense: one learns to write well by studying good writing. However, the emphasis falls almost exclusively on surface features—paragraph structure, thesis placement, transitional devices—rather than on rhetorical strategy, audience awareness, or the generation of ideas.

3.2 Grammar Drills and Handbook Exercises

A substantial portion of instructional time in CTR-informed courses is devoted to grammar drills, sentence-level exercises, and the memorization of usage rules. Handbooks codifying these rules—such as those by Harbrace and Strunk and White—become central course texts. Students complete exercises in subject-verb agreement, pronoun reference, comma usage, and similar mechanical concerns. The assumption underlying this practice is that competence at the sentence level will aggregate into competence at the essay level, a premise that later research on composing processes would call into serious question.

3.3 Thesis-Driven Assignments

Assignments in the current-traditional paradigm are typically thesis-driven. Students are given a topic, asked to formulate a clear thesis statement, and expected to produce an essay that supports that thesis with evidence organized according to prescribed patterns. The thesis statement functions as both a structural anchor and an evaluative criterion: a good essay is one with a clear, arguable

thesis that is consistently and logically supported. This approach privileges a particular kind of academic argumentation and tends to marginalize other forms of intellectual engagement, including exploratory writing, personal narrative, and collaborative inquiry.

3.4 The Teacher as Sole Evaluator

In CTR pedagogy, the teacher occupies the role of sole evaluator. Peer review, collaborative writing, and self-assessment play little or no role. The teacher reads student essays, marks errors, assigns grades, and returns papers with terminal commentary. The evaluative relationship is unidirectional: the student writes for the teacher, and the teacher judges the product. This dynamic reinforces the product orientation of the paradigm and positions the student as a novice whose primary task is to approximate the standards set by the expert instructor.

4 Key Texts and Figures

4.1 Foundational Texts

The foundational texts of CTR include Alexander Bain's *English Composition and Rhetoric* (1866), Adams Sherman Hill's *The Principles of Rhetoric* (1878), and the numerous derivative textbooks that proliferated in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. These works collectively established the conventions—the modes of discourse, the paragraph rules, the emphasis on correctness—that defined the paradigm.

4.2 Robert Connors and the Historical Recovery of CTR

The most comprehensive historical account of CTR is Robert Connors' *Composition-Rhetoric: Backgrounds, Theory, and Pedagogy* (1997). Connors located the beginning of the current-traditional tradition in the mid-nineteenth century and traced its evolution through two centuries of theoretical and pedagogical development. His work demonstrated that American composition-rhetoric constitutes a genuine rhetorical tradition with its own evolving theory and praxis, shaped by historical forces including gender dynamics, the development of textbook publishing, and shifting attitudes toward grammar, style, and invention. Connors showed where many of today's practices and assumptions about writing originate, and he illuminated what those techniques and theories reveal about broader cultural attitudes toward students, language, and intellectual life.

4.3 The 1966 Dartmouth Conference

The Anglo-American Seminar on the Teaching of English, held at Dartmouth College in 1966, is widely regarded as a watershed moment in the history of writing instruction. The conference brought together British and American educators and catalyzed a fundamental shift from product-driven, grammar-heavy approaches to process-oriented, student-centered models of writing instruction. Figures such as James Britton and John Dixon advanced a view of English as *personal growth*, arguing that writing instruction should attend to the developmental needs of individual learners rather than enforcing conformity to abstract textual standards. The Dartmouth Conference did not immediately displace CTR, but it laid the philosophical and pedagogical foundation for the process movement that would gain ascendancy in the 1970s and 1980s.

5 Criticisms

5.1 James Berlin: Ideology and the Myth of Objectivity

James Berlin mounted one of the most influential critiques of CTR in his landmark essay *Rhetoric and Ideology in the Writing Class* (1988) and in his broader scholarly work on rhetorical theory. Berlin argued that CTR presents itself as ideologically neutral—grounded in the objective standards of correct English—when it is in fact deeply ideological. By treating writing as the transparent transcription of pre-formed thought and by emphasizing surface correctness over critical inquiry, CTR serves the interests of existing power structures. It prepares students for participation in capitalist economies by training them to produce standardized, instrumentally effective prose rather than encouraging them to interrogate the social and political dimensions of discourse. Berlin classified CTR as a form of *cognitive rhetoric* that claims the *transcendent neutrality of science* while being *easily preempted by a particular ideological position*. Against CTR, Berlin advocated social-epistemic rhetoric, an approach that makes the question of ideology itself the center of classroom activity.

5.2 Peter Elbow: Writing as Discovery

Peter Elbow's *Writing Without Teachers* (1973) and *Writing With Power* (1981) offered a radically different vision of writing instruction that directly challenged the current-traditional paradigm. Where CTR treated writing as the faithful transcription of prior thought, Elbow argued that writing is itself a mode of thinking and discovery. His technique of freewriting—sustained, uncensored writing without attention to grammar, spelling, or organization—was designed to liberate students from the paralyzing emphasis on correctness that characterized current-traditional classrooms.

Elbow also challenged the authority structure of CTR by advocating teacherless writing groups in which peers, rather than a single expert instructor, provide feedback on drafts. He argued that a teacher “usually isn’t in a position where he can be genuinely affected by your words,” whereas in a teacherless group, participants provide more authentic evidence of how writing communicates.

5.3 Flower and Hayes: The Cognitive Process Model

Linda Flower and John R. Hayes’ “A Cognitive Process Theory of Writing” (1981) provided empirical evidence that the writing process is far more complex than the linear model assumed by CTR. Using think-aloud protocols, Flower and Hayes demonstrated that writing involves a recursive set of cognitive processes—planning, translating, and reviewing—that writers deploy hierarchically and often simultaneously. Their research showed that composing is a *goal-directed thinking process* in which writers continuously generate, evaluate, and revise both their goals and their texts. This model directly contradicted CTR’s assumption that writing proceeds linearly from thought to text and that the finished product is the proper object of evaluation. By making the process of writing visible and theoretically tractable, Flower and Hayes helped to displace CTR’s product orientation with a more empirically grounded understanding of composing.

5.4 Broader Critiques

Beyond these individual figures, CTR has been criticized on several additional grounds. Its emphasis on standard edited English has been challenged as socially exclusionary, privileging the linguistic conventions of white, middle-class speakers and marginalizing speakers of other dialects and languages. Its reliance on the modes of discourse has been shown to be analytically inadequate, since real writing almost always blends multiple modes. Its neglect of audience, purpose, and rhetorical situation has been identified as a fundamental theoretical deficiency. And its mechanical, drill-based pedagogy has been shown by empirical research—most notably George Hillocks’ meta-analysis in *Research on Written Composition* (1986)—to be less effective at improving student writing than alternative approaches emphasizing inquiry, revision, and collaboration.

6 Legacy and Contemporary Relevance

Despite decades of sustained criticism from composition scholars, CTR remains a powerful presence in contemporary writing instruction. Its persistence is attributable to several factors. First, CTR aligns well with the demands of standardized testing. Large-scale writing assessments, including those associated with state-mandated high school examinations and college admissions tests, tend to reward the qualities that CTR emphasizes: clear thesis statements, organized paragraphs,

grammatical correctness, and conventional structure. The five-paragraph essay, in particular, has proven remarkably resilient in secondary education precisely because it is easy to teach, easy to learn, and easy to score.

Second, CTR persists in first-year college composition courses, even in institutions where the official curriculum has moved beyond it. Assignments that require students to use proper documentation formats, correct grammar and mechanics, a prescribed number of research-based sources, and formal academic language reflect CTR's continued influence. The proliferation of standardized high school writing curricula and the institutional pressure to "teach to the test" have reinforced current-traditional approaches at the secondary level, and students arrive at college expecting and sometimes preferring the familiar certainties of thesis-driven, correctness-oriented instruction.

Third, popular writing advice—the kind found in style guides, self-help books, and online resources—is overwhelmingly current-traditional in its assumptions. The emphasis on clear sentences, logical organization, and grammatical propriety that characterizes works from Strunk and White's *The Elements of Style* to contemporary blog posts on "good writing" reflects the deep penetration of CTR into popular literacy culture.

The legacy of CTR is thus paradoxical. Within the academy, it has been thoroughly critiqued and largely supplanted as a theory of writing. Composition scholars almost universally regard it as an inadequate and ideologically problematic framework. Yet in practice, in the lived experience of students and teachers, in the architecture of standardized assessments, and in popular understandings of literacy, Current-Traditional Rhetoric remains the dominant paradigm—the water in which most writers learn to swim, often without knowing its name.

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